

Hamilton, ON to Yellowstone National Park Road Trip Itinerary

Trip Duration: July 4 – July 18, 2026 (15 Days, 14 Nights)

Travelers: 2 Adults (Couple)

Vehicle: Mitsubishi Outlander PHEV

Trip Overview

Route Summary

- **Outbound Route:** Hamilton → Michigan → Wisconsin → South Dakota → Wyoming → Yellowstone
- **Return Route:** Yellowstone → South Dakota → Iowa → Illinois → Chicago (overnight) → Michigan → Ontario
- **Total Distance:** ~5,700 km round trip
- **National Parks Pass:** America the Beautiful Annual Pass — \$80 USD (~\$110 CAD) — Valid for 1 vehicle and all passengers

Key Highlights

- Badlands & Wind Cave National Parks
 - Mount Rushmore & Crazy Horse Memorial
 - Devils Tower National Monument
 - Grand Teton National Park (full dedicated day — Day 9)
 - Lamar Valley wildlife corridor — wolves, bears, bison (Day 6 en route)
 - Yellowstone National Park (3 nights)
 - Chicago downtown overnight (Day 13)
 - Multiple scenic drives with minimal trekking
 - Cedar Rapids overnight option (flexible)
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Day-by-Day Itinerary

Day 1: Saturday, July 4, 2026

Route: Hamilton, ON → Mackinaw City, MI

Distance: 650 km | **Driving Time:** 6.5 hours

Canada Day Note: This is now Independence Day in the USA — expect busier border crossings. Cross early.

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Hamilton 9:00 AM ET

- **Lunch Stop:** Windsor/Sarnia border crossing (~2 hours); cross into Detroit via Ambassador Bridge or Blue Water Bridge
- **Afternoon:** Drive through Michigan — optional quick stop at Port Huron beach
- **Evening:** Arrive Mackinaw City (~4:30 PM ET)
 - Walk along the waterfront
 - View Mackinac Bridge at sunset
 - Visit Colonial Michilimackinac State Park (if time permits)

 Walking Distances — Mackinaw City

Viewpoint / Attraction	Parking → Viewpoint	Notes
Mackinac Bridge viewpoint	~150 m from waterfront lot	Flat, paved — easy stroll
Colonial Michilimackinac entrance	~100 m from park parking	Compact grounds; ~500 m total inside
Port Huron beach (optional)	~50 m from roadside pullout	Drive-up access, minimal walking

 **Tip to reduce walking:** The bridge and waterfront are all within 200 m of each other — park once near the waterfront and walk to all three.

Accommodation

Super 8 by Wyndham Mackinaw City
Address: 519 S Nicolet St, Mackinaw City, MI 49701
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, Wi-Fi
Rate: \$95 USD/night (~\$131 CAD)

Dining

- **Lunch:** Border area — Tim Hortons or quick stop (~\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Mackinaw Grille, Mackinaw City — entrees \$15–25 USD/person (~\$60 USD / ~\$83 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$131
Meals	\$108
Gas (~60L @ \$1.60/L)	\$96
Border toll	\$5
Daily Total	\$340

Day 2: Sunday, July 5, 2026

Route: Mackinaw City, MI → Wisconsin Dells, WI
Distance: 630 km | **Driving Time:** 6.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart 8:30 AM; cross Mackinac Bridge (\$4 USD toll)
- **En Route:** Drive through Upper Peninsula Michigan & Wisconsin; stop at Menominee River scenic overlook
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Wisconsin Dells (~3:00 PM CT)
 - Visit Mirror Lake State Park (free, natural beauty)
 - Walk through downtown Dells
 - Optional: Witches Gulch or Lost Canyon tours (\$15–20 USD pp)

 Walking Distances — Wisconsin Dells

Viewpoint / Attraction	Parking → Viewpoint	Notes
Mirror Lake State Park overlook	~200 m from main lot	Flat, paved path
Downtown Dells main strip	~100 m from street parking	Compact, walkable
Witches Gulch (optional)	~500 m one-way boat + boardwalk	Mostly flat boardwalk
Lost Canyon (optional)	~600 m canyon walk	Flat canyon floor

 **Tip to reduce walking:** Skip Witches Gulch/Lost Canyon if tired — the downtown stroll and Mirror Lake are fully scenic with under 400 m walking total.

Accommodation

Days Inn by Wyndham Wisconsin Dells
Address: 944 Highway 13, Wisconsin Dells, WI 53965
Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi, outdoor pool
Rate: \$88 USD/night (~\$121 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop in Wisconsin (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Moosejaw Pizza & Dells Brewing Co. (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$121
Meals	\$106
Gas (~57L @ \$1.60/L)	\$91

Item	Cost (CAD)
Mackinac Bridge toll	\$6
Optional tour (if taken)	\$55
Daily Total	\$324 (or \$379 with tour)

Day 3: Monday, July 6, 2026

Route: Wisconsin Dells, WI → Rapid City, SD

Distance: 770 km | **Driving Time:** 7.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart 8:00 AM CT; drive through Minnesota & South Dakota
- **Lunch:** Mitchell, SD — see the Corn Palace (free, quirky roadside attraction)
- **Evening:** Arrive Rapid City (~4:30 PM MT)
 - Walk around downtown Rapid City
 - City of Presidents walking tour (free bronze statues)

 Walking Distances — Rapid City

Viewpoint / Attraction	Parking → Viewpoint	Notes
Corn Palace exterior (Mitchell)	~50 m from street parking	Roadside — minimal walking
City of Presidents statues, downtown	~100 m from Main St parking	Statues are spread ~1 km along streets; do a short loop of 4–5 closest ones (~400 m)

 **Tip to reduce walking:** Drive the City of Presidents route slowly and hop out only for statues that interest you most — all are within 50 m of the road.

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Rapid City

Address: 1314 N Elk Vale Rd, Rapid City, SD 57703
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, indoor pool
Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Corn Palace Café, Mitchell, SD (~\$28 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Tally's Silver Spoon, Rapid City (~\$50 USD / ~\$69 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$145
Meals	\$97
Gas (~70L @ \$1.60/L)	\$112
Daily Total	\$354

Day 4: Tuesday, July 7, 2026

Route: Rapid City, SD (Day Trip Loop)
Distance: 240 km loop | **Driving Time:** 5 hours total (with stops)

Attractions & Stops — FULL DAY OF SIGHTSEEING

Morning:

- **Mount Rushmore National Memorial** (1.5–2 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass (otherwise \$10 parking)
- **Custer State Park** (2–3 hours) — Wildlife Loop Road scenic drive; Needles Highway; Sylvan Lake area — Entry: \$20 USD/vehicle (~\$28 CAD)

Afternoon:

- **Crazy Horse Memorial** (1 hour) — Entry: \$15 USD/person (~\$41 CAD for two)
- Return to Rapid City via Iron Mountain Road (scenic tunnels framing Mount Rushmore)

 Walking Distances — Day 4 Sightseeing

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Notes
Mount Rushmore — Grand View Terrace	Main visitor parking	~250 m from parking to terrace	Paved, gentle incline; this is all you need
Mount Rushmore — Presidential Trail	Same parking	~800 m loop (adds closer views)	Optional; mostly flat with some steps — skip if preferred
Custer State Park — Wildlife Loop	Drive-in scenic road	0 m — view from car windows	Bison, pronghorn, burros roadside
Needles Highway granite spires	Cathedral Spires trailhead pullout	~0–50 m roadside pullouts	Drive-through; tunnels are the main attraction
Sylvan Lake (optional)	Sylvan Lake parking	~300 m easy lakeside loop	Flat, paved — very scenic; skip if short on time
Crazy Horse Memorial	Visitor center lot	~100 m to terrace viewpoint	All viewing from terrace; no trail needed

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Notes
Iron Mountain Road pigtail bridges	Roadside pullouts	~0–100 m from car	Drive slowly and stop at tunnels for framed Rushmore views

 Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 4:

1. Mount Rushmore → walk only to Grand View Terrace (250 m, ~10 min) — skip Presidential Trail
2. Drive Wildlife Loop Road in Custer SP (pure car experience)
3. Drive Needles Highway — stop at 2–3 pullouts only (under 100 m each)
4. Crazy Horse → terrace viewpoint (100 m)
5. Iron Mountain Road back — tunnel photo stops only

Total walking for the day: under 700 m while seeing everything.

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Rapid City (same as previous night)
Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** State Game Lodge, Custer State Park — buffalo burger! (~\$45 USD / ~\$62 CAD for two)
- **Dinner:** Murphy's Pub & Grill, Rapid City (~\$48 USD / ~\$66 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$145
Meals	\$128
Gas (~22L @ \$1.60/L)	\$35
Custer State Park entry	\$28
Crazy Horse entry	\$41
Daily Total	\$377

Day 5: Wednesday, July 8, 2026

Route: Rapid City, SD → Cody, WY
Distance: 560 km | **Driving Time:** 6 hours

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- **Badlands National Park** (2–3 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass
 - Drive Badlands Loop Road (Hwy 240) — 31 miles of scenic overlooks
 - Stop at: Pinnacles Overlook, Yellow Mounds, Panorama Point, Big Badlands Overlook

Afternoon:

- **Devils Tower National Monument** (1.5 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass
- **Evening:** Arrive Cody, WY

Walking Distances — Day 5 Sightseeing

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Badlands — Big Badlands Overlook	Roadside pullout	~30 m from car	Best panoramic view; drive-up
Badlands — Pinnacles Overlook	Pinnacles Overlook lot	~50 m from car	Flat gravel path
Badlands — Yellow Mounds Overlook	Roadside pullout	~20 m from car	Drive-up pullout
Badlands — Panorama Point	Small lot	~50 m from car	Flat, paved
Badlands — Door Trail boardwalk (optional)	Ben Reifel Visitor Center lot	0.75 km boardwalk (flat)	Fully accessible; great canyon views
Badlands — Fossil Exhibit Trail (optional)	Fossil Exhibit pullout	0.4 km paved loop	Fully flat; fossils under glass
Devils Tower — viewpoint from parking area	Tower Trail lot	~200 m to best view angle	Flat paved path
Devils Tower — Red Beds Trail partial (optional)	Same lot	1.5 km partial loop	Mostly flat; great alternate angles — do first 400 m only for extra views

Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 5:

- Badlands: Drive Loop Road and stop at 4–5 pullouts (all under 50 m from car). Add Door Trail boardwalk only if energized (0.75 km flat).
- Devils Tower: Walk 200 m to main viewpoint from parking. Optionally add 400 m of Red Beds for tower-close view. Skip full loop.
- **Total walking: 400–900 m for the full day.**

Accommodation

Hampton Inn Cody

Address: 1807 Sheridan Ave, Cody, WY 82414

Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, indoor pool
Rate: \$115 USD/night (~\$159 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Cedar Pass Lodge, Badlands or packed sandwiches (~\$35 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Wyoming's Rib & Chop House, Cody (~\$60 USD / ~\$83 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$159
Meals	\$118
Gas (~51L @ \$1.60/L)	\$82
Daily Total	\$359

Day 6: Thursday, July 9, 2026

Route: Cody, WY → Lamar Valley → Yellowstone Lake Overlook → West Yellowstone, MT
Distance: 343 km | **Driving Time:** ~5h 10min (per Google Maps, via WY-296 & US-212 W)

Route Note: This is the scenic Beartooth Highway approach entering Yellowstone through the **Northeast Entrance** via Cooke City, MT — considered one of the most spectacular drives in North America. You'll pass through Lamar Valley mid-route then exit via the park's south end past Yellowstone Lake before arriving at West Yellowstone. Note: this route has tolls (Northeast Entrance park fee — covered by your America the Beautiful Pass). Fill up gas in Cody before departing as there are limited stations on this mountain route.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- **Buffalo Bill Center of the West**, Cody (2 hours max — keep it brief to allow time for the drive) — Entry: \$21 USD/person (~\$58 CAD for two)
- Depart Cody by 10:00 AM; head north on WY-296 (Chief Joseph Scenic Byway)

Mid-Morning:

- **Chief Joseph Scenic Byway / WY-296** — dramatic canyon and mountain scenery; roadside pullouts along the way
- Enter Yellowstone via **Northeast Entrance** (near Cooke City, MT)

Late Morning – Early Afternoon:

- 🐾 **Lamar Valley** — "Serengeti of North America" (1.5–2 hours)
 - Best wildlife viewing in all of Yellowstone: bison herds, wolves, bears, elk, pronghorn

- View entirely from car and roadside pullouts — no hiking needed
- Drive the full Lamar Valley stretch slowly (~30 km); stop at pullouts as wildlife appears
- **This is the best time of day for wildlife — late morning light is ideal**

Afternoon:

- Continue south through the park (Tower Junction → Canyon → Fishing Bridge)
- **Yellowstone Lake Overlook Trail area** — pullouts along the north shore of Yellowstone Lake
 - Lake Butte Overlook: stunning panoramic view over the lake (drive-up)
 - Fishing Bridge area: pelicans, osprey, cutthroat trout visible from bridge (walk across bridge — ~200 m)

Evening:

- Exit via West Entrance; arrive West Yellowstone (~5:30–6:00 PM)
- Walk around town, visit shops

 Walking Distances — Day 6

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Buffalo Bill Center of the West	On-site lot	~50 m to entrance	All indoor — keep visit to 2 hrs max
Chief Joseph Scenic Byway pullouts	Roadside pullouts	~20–50 m from car	Mountain canyon views; drive-up
Lamar Valley wildlife viewing	Multiple roadside pullouts along Lamar Valley Rd	0–30 m from car	Stay in or beside car; bison may approach road
Fishing Bridge	Fishing Bridge parking area	~200 m across bridge (flat)	Watch for osprey and pelicans from the bridge
Yellowstone Lake — Lake Butte Overlook	Roadside pullout (East Entrance Rd)	~30–50 m from car	Best lake panorama; completely drive-up
West Yellowstone town stroll	Hotel parking	~100–200 m along Madison Ave	Flat, relaxed evening walk

 **Optimized Tip for Day 6:** Lamar Valley is 100% a car-window and roadside experience — you don't need to leave the vehicle at all unless you spot wildlife at a pullout. Budget 90 minutes to drive slowly through the full valley, stopping wherever herds appear. This maximises sightings with zero walking effort.

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone

Address: 209 Madison Ave, West Yellowstone, MT 59758
Features: Level 2 EV charging (ChargePoint), free breakfast, hot tub
Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel; eat early before departing
- **Lunch:** Pack sandwiches from hotel / grab in Cody before departure — limited options inside the Northeast entrance (~\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Wild West Pizzeria & Saloon, West Yellowstone (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$186
Meals	\$101
Gas (~31L @ \$1.60/L — longer route)	\$50
Buffalo Bill Center entry	\$58
Daily Total	\$395

Day 7: Friday, July 10, 2026

YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK — Day 1 (Lower Loop)

Distance: 150 km in park | Driving Time: Full day with stops

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Enter Yellowstone West Entrance (7:00 AM — beat crowds!)
- **Lower Geyser Basin — Fountain Paint Pot**
- **Midway Geyser Basin — Grand Prismatic Spring**
- **Old Faithful area**

Afternoon:

- **West Thumb Geyser Basin** on Yellowstone Lake
- Drive along Yellowstone Lake shore
- **Lake Butte Overlook**

Evening: Return to West Yellowstone

 Walking Distances — Yellowstone Day 1

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Loop	Recommendation
Fountain Paint Pot, Lower Geyser Basin	Fountain Paint Pot lot	~100 m to boardwalk start	0.8 km loop (flat)	✅ Do the full loop — all flat boardwalk, multiple features

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Loop	Recommendation
Grand Prismatic Spring, Midway Geyser Basin	Midway Geyser Basin lot	~50 m to boardwalk	0.8 km loop (flat)	✅ Do the full loop — THE highlight, completely flat
Grand Prismatic Overlook Trail (optional)	Fairy Falls trailhead, 0.8 km south	1.3 km uphill each way	—	⚠️ Skip — aerial view is great but significant uphill; the boardwalk at ground level is equally impressive
Old Faithful Geyser	Old Faithful Visitor Center lot	~200 m to viewing benches	—	✅ Watch from benches — 200 m flat walk from car
Upper Geyser Basin boardwalk	Old Faithful lot	~200 m to start of boardwalk	1–3 km depending on extension	✅ Do first 800 m to Beehive/Castle/Riverside Geysers; skip extension to Morning Glory Pool (adds 2 km)
Morning Glory Pool (optional extension)	Old Faithful lot	~2.4 km one-way	—	⚠️ Skip — pool is beautiful but very long walk; not worth it on a packed day
West Thumb Geyser Basin	West Thumb lot	~50 m to boardwalk	0.9 km loop (flat)	✅ Do the full loop — lakeside thermal features, fully flat
Lake Butte Overlook	Roadside pullout (6 km past fishing bridge)	~50 m from car	—	✅ Drive-up viewpoint

● Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 7:

1. Fountain Paint Pot — 0.8 km flat loop ✅
2. Grand Prismatic Spring — 0.8 km flat loop ✅ (skip overlook trail)
3. Old Faithful — 200 m to benches; watch eruption ✅
4. Upper Geyser Basin — walk 800 m only (to Riverside Geyser) ✅
5. West Thumb Geyser Basin — 0.9 km flat loop ✅
6. Lake Butte Overlook — drive-up ✅

Total walking: ~3.5 km across the entire day (all flat boardwalks).

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone (same hotel)

Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Packed sandwiches/snacks (buy groceries evening before) (~\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Running Bear Pancake House, West Yellowstone (~\$50 USD / ~\$69 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$186
Meals	\$94
Gas (~14L @ \$1.60/L)	\$22
Groceries for next day	\$30
Daily Total	\$332

Day 8: Saturday, July 11, 2026

YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK — Day 2 (Upper Loop)

Distance: 180 km in park | **Driving Time:** Full day with stops

Note: July 4th has passed — this weekend is still peak summer but crowds are more manageable. Start early (6:00 AM) regardless.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Depart 6:00 AM
- **Norris Geyser Basin**
- **Mammoth Hot Springs**

Afternoon:

- **Tower-Roosevelt area** (scenic drive)
- **Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone**

Evening:

- **Hayden Valley** — prime wildlife viewing

 Walking Distances — Yellowstone Day 2

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Option	Recommendation
Norris Geyser Basin — Porcelain Basin	Norris lot	~100 m to boardwalk start	0.8 km loop (flat)	 Do Porcelain Basin loop — the most dramatic, all flat

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Option	Recommendation
Norris Geyser Basin — Back Basin	Same lot	~150 m to boardwalk start	1.5 km loop (mostly flat)	⚠️ Optional — skip or do first 400 m to Steamboat Geyser only
Mammoth Hot Springs — Lower Terraces	Lower Terraces lot	~50 m to boardwalk	0.6 km loop (flat)	✅ Do the Lower Terraces — most colourful, fully flat
Mammoth Hot Springs — Upper Terraces	Upper Terraces one-way road (drive)	~100 m per pullout	Drive-through loop	✅ Drive the one-way upper terrace road — park at pullouts, walk 50–100 m to each terrace
Grand Canyon of Yellowstone — Artist Point	Artist Point lot	~150 m paved path to viewpoint	—	✅ Must-do — iconic falls view, 150 m flat walk
Grand Canyon — Lookout Point	North Rim lot	~200 m to canyon rim	—	✅ Great secondary view, 200 m easy walk
Grand Canyon — Brink of Lower Falls (optional)	Brink lot	0.5 km downhill then back up	—	⚠️ Skip — steep and strenuous; Artist Point gives equal drama
Uncle Tom's Trail	South Rim lot	328 steps down + back up	—	❌ Skip — very strenuous
Hayden Valley wildlife pullouts	Multiple roadside pullouts	0–30 m from car	—	✅ View bison herds from car or roadside

● Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 8:

1. Norris — Porcelain Basin loop (0.8 km flat) ✅
2. Mammoth — Lower Terraces loop (0.6 km flat) + drive Upper Terraces ✅
3. Grand Canyon — Artist Point (150 m) + Lookout Point (200 m) ✅
4. Hayden Valley — wildlife from car windows ✅

Total walking: ~1.8 km for the entire day.

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone (same hotel)

Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel (early buffet)
- **Lunch:** Packed lunch from groceries (\$0 — already purchased)
- **Dinner:** Serenity Bistro, West Yellowstone (~\$58 USD / ~\$80 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$186
Meals	\$80
Gas (~16L @ \$1.60/L)	\$26
Daily Total	\$292

Day 9: Sunday, July 12, 2026

GRAND TETON — Full Day

Route: West Yellowstone → Grand Teton National Park → Jackson, WY

Distance: ~180 km | **Driving Time:** ~2.5 hours driving + full day in park

Day 9 Focus: With Lamar Valley now done on Day 6, today is entirely devoted to **Grand Teton National Park** — giving you a leisurely full day to enjoy the most photogenic mountain scenery in the American West without rushing. You'll enter the park from the north (from Yellowstone's South Entrance) and work your way south to Jackson, hitting every iconic viewpoint along the way at your own pace.

Attractions & Stops

Morning (depart West Yellowstone 7:30 AM):

- Drive south from West Yellowstone through Yellowstone's south section (~1.5 hrs)
- Enter Grand Teton National Park via **North Entrance (Moran Junction)**
- **Oxbow Bend** — first stop; stunning Teton reflection in still water, especially beautiful in morning light
- **Signal Mountain Summit Road** (*optional — 8 km paved side road, drive to top*) — panoramic 360° view of the entire Teton Range and Jackson Hole Valley from above; completely driveable to summit

Mid-Morning:

- **Jenny Lake** — allow 45–60 minutes here
 - Walk to lakefront for the classic Teton-over-water reflection shot (~200 m from South lot)
 - Optional: sit at the lakeside benches and enjoy the view — no rush today
 - Optional: Jenny Lake Visitor Center (free, small but worthwhile)
- **String Lake Picnic Area** — beautiful spot for a mid-morning snack break; calm lake, Teton backdrop

Late Morning – Lunch:

- **Schwabacher Landing** — drive the short dirt road to the river; iconic beaver pond reflection of the Tetons (~200 m flat walk from lot)

- **Lunch at Dornan's in Moose** — casual outdoor patio with one of the best Teton views from any restaurant (~\$40 USD / ~\$55 CAD for two)

Afternoon:

- **Snake River Overlook** — the Ansel Adams viewpoint; roadside pullout, ~30 m walk, unmissable
- **Mormon Row Historic District** — T.A. Moulton Barn with the Tetons rising behind it; one of the most photographed spots in the USA. Walk to the barns (~50–150 m from roadside parking)
- **Antelope Flats Road** — slow drive through open sage flats; excellent pronghorn, bison, and bald eagle sightings from the car
- **National Museum of Wildlife Art** (optional, Jackson) — Entry ~\$15 USD pp; stunning building perched above the National Elk Refuge; architecture alone is worth the stop

Late Afternoon – Evening:

- Arrive **Jackson** (~4:00–5:00 PM)
- Walk Jackson Town Square (elk antler arches) — ~5 min from hotel
- Browse galleries and shops on Broadway/Cache St
- Enjoy a relaxed dinner

Walking Distances — Grand Teton Full Day

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Option	Recommendation
Oxbow Bend	Roadside pullout (Hwy 89, north of Moran Jct)	~30 m from car	—	✓ Drive-up; best in morning light
Signal Mountain Summit	Signal Mountain Summit lot	0 m — drive to top	Short 50 m walk to overlook rail	✓ Completely driveable; do it — extraordinary 360° view
Jenny Lake lakefront	Jenny Lake South lot	~200 m to water's edge	3.9 km loop (skip)	✓ Walk 200 m to lakefront only; spend time sitting and enjoying
String Lake Picnic Area	String Lake lot	~100 m to lakeshore	—	✓ Gentle flat walk; great snack/rest stop
Schwabacher Landing	Schwabacher Rd dirt lot	~200 m to beaver ponds	—	✓ Flat gravel; best reflection photography in park
Dornan's Patio, Moose	Dornan's lot	~50 m to restaurant patio	—	✓ Lunch with unbeatable Teton view
Snake River Overlook	Roadside pullout (Hwy 89)	~30 m from car	—	✓ Iconic Ansel Adams spot; drive-up

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Option	Recommendation
Mormon Row — T.A. Moulton Barn	Roadside dirt parking	~100–150 m to main barn	~300 m to second barn	✓ Flat dirt path; walk to both barns for different angles
Antelope Flats Road wildlife drive	Drive-through	0 m — car windows	—	✓ Pure car experience; pronghorn and bison roadside
National Museum of Wildlife Art (optional)	Museum lot	~100 m to entrance	Indoor	⚠ Optional; great if you enjoy wildlife art; \$15 USD pp
Jackson Town Square	Town Square lot	~50 m to antler arches	—	✓ Quick and flat; nice evening stroll

● **Optimized Full-Day Grand Teton Route (North → South, no backtracking):**

- 1. Oxbow Bend — 30 m walk, morning reflection ✓
- 2. Signal Mountain Summit — drive to top, 50 m to overlook ✓
- 3. Jenny Lake — 200 m lakefront walk + rest ✓
- 4. Schwabacher Landing — 200 m flat walk ✓
- 5. Dornan's lunch — 50 m walk ✓
- 6. Snake River Overlook — 30 m walk ✓
- 7. Mormon Row — 150 m walk to barns ✓
- 8. Antelope Flats — car windows ✓
- 9. Arrive Jackson — evening stroll ✓

Total walking: ~1,010 m across 8 iconic spots — a deeply satisfying full day with under 1.1 km of walking total.

Accommodation

Elk Country Inn — Jackson Hole

Address: 480 W Pearl Ave, Jackson, WY 83001
Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi
Rate: \$125 USD/night (~\$172 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel; eat before departing
- **Lunch:** Dornan's Patio, Moose, WY — outdoor patio with Teton views (~\$40 USD / ~\$55 CAD for two)
- **Dinner:** Bubba's Bar-B-Que, Jackson — classic Western BBQ (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$172
Meals	\$131
Gas (~16L @ \$1.60/L)	\$26
Optional: Wildlife Art Museum (2 pp)	\$41
Daily Total	\$329 (or \$370 with museum)

Day 10: Monday, July 13, 2026

Route: Jackson, WY → Sioux Falls, SD

Distance: ~760 km | **Driving Time:** ~7.5 hours

Why this routing? This is the longest driving day of the return trip, but it's also the most logical — it crosses the boring Wyoming/South Dakota plains efficiently in one shot, eliminates the redundant Custer overnight (you've already seen Mount Rushmore, Crazy Horse, and Custer SP on Days 4–5), and sets up a smooth eastward progression. Depart early, stop at Sioux Falls for a genuinely beautiful city park, and rest well for the Dells/Chicago run ahead.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Depart Jackson 7:30 AM after hotel breakfast
- Quick final walk around **Jackson Town Square** elk antler arches if desired (~50 m, 10 min)
- Drive east on US-26 through the Wind River Canyon area — scenic Wyoming high desert

Midday:

- Lunch stop in **Douglas or Lusk, WY** — roadside diner, stretch legs
- Continue east on I-90 through South Dakota

Afternoon:

- Brief en-route stop: **Mitchell Corn Palace, SD** — free, quirky, 20-min stop (~50 m from parking to entrance)
- Continue east on I-90 toward Sioux Falls

Late Afternoon (~5:00 PM):

- Arrive **Sioux Falls, SD**
- **Falls Park** — genuinely stunning urban waterfall park; walk to upper viewing platform (~200 m from lot)
- Best light for photos is late afternoon — you're arriving at the perfect time
- Optional: **SculptureWalk** along Phillips Ave downtown (~200 m stroll)

Evening: Check in, dinner, early night — big drive behind you, fun days ahead.

 Walking Distances — Day 10

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Jackson Town Square antler arches	Town Square lot	~50 m to square centre	Quick flat stroll; 10 min max
Mitchell Corn Palace	Street parking on Main St	~50 m to entrance	Drive-up; free; 20-min stop
Falls Park upper viewing platform	Falls Park lot off River Blvd	~200 m to platform	Flat, paved; best single view of all falls
Falls Park lower river path (optional)	Same lot	~400 m additional	Gentle descent to water level
SculptureWalk, downtown (optional)	Phillips Ave parking	~50 m to first sculpture	Flat; stroll as far as you like

 **Tip:** Falls Park upper platform (200 m) is all you need — the full panorama of the Big Sioux River cascading over pink quartzite is genuinely impressive and worth the brief stop. You'll arrive in perfect late-afternoon golden light.

Accommodation

Hilton Garden Inn Sioux Falls Downtown

Address: 201 E 8th St, Sioux Falls, SD 57104
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, central location
Rate: \$109 USD/night (~\$150 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel; eat early before departing
- **Lunch:** Roadside diner, Douglas or Lusk WY (~\$35 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Parker's Bistro, Sioux Falls — upscale casual, excellent local steaks (~\$65 USD / ~\$90 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$150
Meals	\$125
Gas (~69L @ \$1.60/L)	\$110
Daily Total	\$385

Day 11: Tuesday, July 14, 2026

Route: Sioux Falls, SD → Wisconsin Dells, WI

Distance: ~620 km | **Driving Time:** ~6 hours

Why this routing? A comfortable 6-hour drive that cuts diagonally northeast through Minnesota and into Wisconsin — far more manageable than Copilot's 1,150 km/10.5-hour suggestion which would leave you arriving exhausted. You'll cross the Mississippi River near La Crosse (a beautiful stretch of I-90), and arrive in Wisconsin Dells by mid-afternoon with time to scope out the town and plan tomorrow's full day.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Depart Sioux Falls 8:00 AM
- Drive northeast on I-90 through southern Minnesota
- **Albert Lea, MN** — brief rest stop at Fountain Lake overlook (~30 m from parking lot); charming small city with lakefront

Midday:

- Cross into Wisconsin at La Crosse
- Lunch in **La Crosse, WI** on the Mississippi River blufftop or downtown (~\$35 CAD)
- **Grandad Bluff Park, La Crosse** (optional, 15-min detour) — drive to summit for stunning panoramic view of the Mississippi River valley; one of the best free viewpoints in the Midwest (~100 m from parking to overlook)

Afternoon:

- Continue east on I-90 into Wisconsin Dells (~90 min from La Crosse)
- Arrive Wisconsin Dells (~3:30 PM)
- **Scout the Dells** — walk downtown Broadway strip, check tour departure times for tomorrow
- Book any tours in advance if needed (Lost Canyon, Witches Gulch — recommended to reserve morning slots)
- **Riverwalk along the Wisconsin River** — lovely evening stroll (~500 m flat riverside path)

Evening: Relax, review tomorrow's tour plan, early dinner.

Walking Distances — Day 11

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Albert Lea Fountain Lake overlook (optional)	Bridge Ave pullout	~30 m from car	Quick scenic stop
Grandad Bluff Park, La Crosse (optional)	Summit parking lot	~100 m to main overlook	Drive to summit; 360° Mississippi valley views
Wisconsin Dells Broadway strip	Public lot off Broadway	~100 m to main strip	Scout for tomorrow; flat

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Wisconsin River Riverwalk	Riverwalk trailhead lot	~500 m flat path	Beautiful evening stroll along the river

 **Tip:** Grandad Bluff is a 15-min detour off I-90 in La Crosse and completely worth it — drive to the summit parking lot, walk 100 m to the overlook, and get a stunning view of three states (WI, MN, IA) across the Mississippi valley. Zero effort, maximum payoff.

Accommodation

Chula Vista Resort — Wisconsin Dells

Address: 2501 River Rd, Wisconsin Dells, WI 53965
Features: On the Wisconsin River, EV charging, indoor waterpark access, free breakfast
Rate: \$129 USD/night (~\$178 CAD)

Upgrade note: Chula Vista is a step up from the original Days Inn — it sits directly on the river, gives you waterpark access for a relaxing evening, and puts you close to all the Dells tour departure points for tomorrow.

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Downtown La Crosse, WI — River City Roots café or similar (~\$35 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Houlihan's or Moosejaw Pizza & Dells Brewing Co., Wisconsin Dells (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$178
Meals	\$111
Gas (~56L @ \$1.60/L)	\$90
Daily Total	\$379

Day 12: Wednesday, July 15, 2026 — Wisconsin Dells Full Day 

Route: Wisconsin Dells (full day — no driving)
Distance: 0 km

This is the Dells completion day — everything you may have skimmed or missed on Day 2 of the outbound trip, now done properly with a full day and no pressure to move on. Wisconsin Dells is far more interesting than its waterpark reputation suggests — the actual river canyon geology is genuinely spectacular, and the boat/canyon tours are unique experiences you won't find elsewhere.

Full Day Tour Plan — Recommended Order

Morning (8:30 AM start):

Lost Canyon Tour (9:00 AM — book first slot)

- Horse-drawn wagon tour through a narrow sandstone canyon
- Duration: ~45 minutes | Cost: ~\$16 USD pp (~\$44 CAD for two)
- Departure: Lost Canyon, 720 Canyon Rd, Wisconsin Dells
- Walking: ~0 m — seated wagon ride entire way; canyon walls pass within arm's reach

Original Wisconsin Ducks (10:30 AM)

- Amphibious WWII DUKW boat that drives into the Wisconsin River and onto land
- Sees canyon rock formations, Hidden Valley, and river scenery from the water
- Duration: ~1 hour | Cost: ~\$35 USD pp (~\$96 CAD for two)
- Walking: ~50 m from parking to boarding dock

Late Morning:

Witches Gulch Boat Tour (12:00 PM — Upper Dells)

- Scenic riverboat cruise to Witches Gulch — a narrow slot canyon only accessible by boat
- Walk the 500 m canyon boardwalk (flat, well-maintained) inside the gulch
- Duration: ~2 hours total (boat + boardwalk) | Cost: ~\$40 USD pp (~\$110 CAD for two)
- Walking: ~500 m flat boardwalk inside canyon — the highlight of the Dells experience

Afternoon:

 **Lunch** (2:00 PM) — Moosejaw Pizza & Dells Brewing Co., or Henny Penny restaurant (~\$40 USD / ~\$55 CAD for two)

Mirror Lake State Park (3:00 PM — optional, if energy allows)

- Serene natural lake surrounded by sandstone bluffs; complete contrast to the touristy Dells
- Drive 10 min south of town; park at Echo Rock lot
- Walking: ~300 m flat lakeside path to best bluff views

Evening:

- **Downtown Broadway strip** — souvenir shops, fudge, ice cream, classic Dells kitsch
- **Wisconsin River Riverwalk** — sunset walk along the river (~500 m flat)
- Early dinner at hotel or downtown

Walking Distances — Wisconsin Dells Full Day

Attraction	Departure Point	Walking Required	Notes
Lost Canyon Tour	720 Canyon Rd lot	~0 m — seated wagon	Canyon walls 1–2 m away from wagon seats

Attraction	Departure Point	Walking Required	Notes
Original Wisconsin Ducks	Duck Tours lot	~50 m to boarding	Seated amphibious vehicle throughout
Witches Gulch — boardwalk	River tour boat dock	~500 m flat boardwalk	Slot canyon walls tower overhead; entirely flat
Mirror Lake State Park (optional)	Echo Rock lot	~300 m flat lakeside	Peaceful; good if you want nature after the tours
Downtown Broadway strip	Public lot	~200–400 m browsing	Flat; stroll as far as you like
Wisconsin River Riverwalk	Hotel / Riverwalk lot	~500 m flat	Lovely sunset walk

Total walking for the day: ~550–800 m (excluding optional Mirror Lake), across three major tours.

 **Booking Note:** Reserve Lost Canyon and Witches Gulch online in advance — peak July slots fill quickly. Wisconsin Ducks can usually be booked same-morning but earlier slots are better.

Accommodation

Chula Vista Resort — Wisconsin Dells (same hotel, 2nd night)
Rate: \$129 USD/night (~\$178 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Moosejaw Pizza & Dells Brewing Co. (~\$40 USD / ~\$55 CAD for two)
- **Dinner:** Ishnala Supper Club — iconic Wisconsin supper club on Mirror Lake; book ahead (~\$70 USD / ~\$96 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$178
Meals	\$151
Lost Canyon Tour (2 pp)	\$44
Wisconsin Ducks (2 pp)	\$96
Witches Gulch Boat Tour (2 pp)	\$110
Gas (local only, ~5L)	\$8
Daily Total	\$587

Day 13: Thursday, July 16, 2026 — Chicago Arrival Day 

Route: Wisconsin Dells → Chicago, IL

Distance: ~290 km | **Driving Time:** ~3 hours

The short drive pays off: Arriving by noon gives you a genuine afternoon and evening in Chicago — not a rushed 2-hour sprint. Combined with the full Day 14, you're getting effectively 1.5 full days in one of North America's greatest cities. Park the car at the hotel and use the CTA or walk everywhere.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Leisurely breakfast at Chula Vista; check out by 9:30 AM
- Depart Wisconsin Dells ~9:30 AM; easy 3-hour drive south on I-90/94
- **Note:** Pre-book hotel parking or use SpotHero app before arriving — Chicago garage rates are \$35–55/night but SpotHero can get you \$20–30

Midday:

- Arrive Chicago ~12:30 PM; check in (or drop luggage if room not ready)
- **Lunch on the Magnificent Mile** — Eataly Chicago (food hall, grab-and-go Italian) or Billy Goat Tavern (legendary underground diner, immortalised by SNL's "Cheezborger" sketch) (~\$35 USD / ~\$48 CAD for two)

Afternoon:

- **Millennium Park** — Cloud Gate "The Bean" (free; best photos mid-afternoon when sky reflects in the sculpture)
- **Art Institute of Chicago** (optional — 2–3 hours) — one of the world's great art museums; Entry ~\$26 USD pp (~\$71 CAD for two); right beside Millennium Park
- **Chicago Riverwalk** — walk the entire 2.5 km river-level promenade; grab a drink at one of the riverside bars

Evening:

- **Navy Pier** — free to walk; Ferris wheel (\$18 pp if desired); great lakefront views
- Sunset over Lake Michigan from the pier is stunning
- **Deep dish pizza dinner** — Giordano's or Lou Malnati's (note: order 45 min in advance; deep dish takes time) (~\$65 USD / ~\$90 CAD for two)

Walking Distances — Chicago Day 1

Attraction	Parking / Base	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Billy Goat Tavern, Magnificent Mile	Hotel or Michigan Ave garage	~300 m to lower Michigan Ave entrance	Flat; underground diner
Cloud Gate "The Bean", Millennium Park	Park once at hotel or Grant Park garage	~400 m from garage to Cloud Gate	Flat, paved; park here and walk to everything

Attraction	Parking / Base	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Art Institute of Chicago	Same garage (Grant Park)	~500 m from Cloud Gate	Flat; world-class collection
Chicago Riverwalk	Wacker Dr staircase near Michigan Ave	~100 m down to river level	Flat riverside promenade; 2.5 km total if you walk the whole thing
Navy Pier entrance	Hotel (CTA bus #29 runs direct)	~100 m from bus stop	Flat; ride the bus, avoid pier parking
Lake Michigan lakefront sunset	Navy Pier east end	~600 m from pier entrance to tip	Flat pier walk

● **Parking Strategy:** Use SpotHero to pre-book one spot near your hotel for the entire Chicago stay. Use CTA buses and walking for everything — you do not need to move the car until departure on Day 15. The CTA #6 and #29 buses cover Millennium Park, Navy Pier, and the lakefront corridor.

Accommodation

Hampton Inn Chicago Downtown / N Loop / Michigan Ave

Address: 68 E Wacker Pl, Chicago, IL 60601
Features: Free breakfast, central location, walking distance to all major attractions
Rate: \$145 USD/night (~\$200 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel (eat well — big day)
- **Lunch:** Billy Goat Tavern or Eataly Chicago (~\$48 CAD for two)
- **Dinner:** Giordano's or Lou Malnati's — deep dish pizza (~\$65 USD / ~\$90 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$200
Meals	\$138
Gas (~26L @ \$1.60/L)	\$42
Hotel parking (SpotHero)	\$30
Optional Art Institute (2 pp)	\$71
Daily Total	\$410 (or \$481 with Art Institute)

Day 14: Friday, July 17, 2026 — Chicago Full Day 🗺️

Route: Chicago (full day — no driving)
Distance: 0 km

Your complete Chicago day. The car stays parked. Use the CTA or walk everywhere. Pick **one theme** and go deep rather than rushing everything — you'll enjoy it far more. Three curated options below; mix and match freely.

Option A — Architecture & Skyline (Recommended for First-Time Chicago Visitors)

Morning:

- **Chicago Architecture Foundation River Cruise** (9:30 AM — book ahead)
 - 90-min narrated boat tour under 50+ bridges through the canyon of skyscrapers
 - Cost: ~\$52 USD pp (~\$143 CAD for two) — the single best way to understand Chicago's built environment
 - Departs: Chicago Architecture Center, 111 E Wacker Dr (3 min walk from hotel)
 - Walking: ~300 m from hotel to dock

Late Morning:

- **Willis Tower Skydeck** (The Ledge — glass floor boxes extending over the city)
 - Cost: ~\$32 USD pp (~\$88 CAD for two)
 - Walking: ~800 m from hotel (or CTA Brown Line to Quincy)
 - Book online to skip the queue

Afternoon:

- **Magnificent Mile** — walk the full stretch of Michigan Ave from the river to Oak St Beach
 - Chicago Water Tower (free landmark; 15-min stop)
 - Window-shopping, people-watching, iconic Chicago streetscape
 - Walking: ~1.5 km one-way, completely flat
- **Oak St Beach** — small but beautiful Lake Michigan beach at the end of Magnificent Mile
 - Stunning skyline view looking south from the waterfront
 - Walking: ~100 m from Oak St to beach

Evening:

- **Chicago Riverwalk sunset drinks** — grab a table at one of the riverside bars (RPM on the Water, Terrace 16) for golden hour over the river
- **Dinner: Portillo's** — legendary Chicago-style hot dogs and Italian beef sandwiches; a local institution (~\$35 USD / ~\$48 CAD for two) OR splurge at **Gibsons Bar & Steakhouse** (~\$90 USD / ~\$124 CAD for two)

Option B — Museums & Culture (Best for a Rainy Day)

Time	Attraction	Cost (2 pp CAD)	Walking from Hotel
9:00 AM	Field Museum (natural history)	~\$77	CTA #146 bus (20 min)
1:00 PM	Shedd Aquarium (next door to Field)	~\$90	~200 m from Field Museum

Time	Attraction	Cost (2 pp CAD)	Walking from Hotel
3:30 PM	Adler Planetarium (next door to Shedd)	~\$55	~300 m from Shedd
6:00 PM	Museum Campus lakefront sunset walk	Free	~200 m
7:30 PM	Dinner in South Loop	~\$55	CTA back

All three museums are on the same lakefront Museum Campus — visit them in sequence without moving the car. One CTA bus ride each way.

Option C — Neighbourhoods & Local Life

Morning: Lincoln Park — free zoo (Lincoln Park Zoo, open 7 AM), lakefront path, conservatory; CTA Red Line to Fullerton

Late Morning: Wicker Park — Chicago's creative neighbourhood; coffee at Dove's Luncheonette, browse independent shops on Milwaukee Ave

Afternoon: Chinatown — one of the most vibrant in North America; lunch at MingHin Cuisine or Three Happiness; Chinatown Gate photo; Ping Tom Memorial Park on the river

Evening: Greektown — dinner at Athena or Greek Islands restaurant (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two); walking neighbourhood with great energy

 Walking Distances — Chicago Full Day (Option A)

Attraction	Base	Walk	Notes
Architecture River Cruise dock	Hotel (68 E Wacker)	~300 m to Chicago Architecture Center	Flat; 3-min walk
Willis Tower Skydeck	Hotel	~800 m or CTA Brown Line	Flat; book tickets online to skip queue
Magnificent Mile walk	Michigan Ave & Wacker	~1.5 km one-way	Completely flat; iconic Chicago streetscape
Oak St Beach	End of Magnificent Mile	~100 m from Oak St	Flat sand; stunning skyline view south
Riverwalk sunset	Hotel area	~100 m to Riverwalk staircase	Flat; waterfront bars and restaurants

Total walking (Option A): ~3–4 km spread across the full day at a relaxed pace — entirely flat.

Accommodation

Hampton Inn Chicago Downtown / N Loop / Michigan Ave (same hotel, 2nd night)
Rate: \$145 USD/night (~\$200 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Varies by option — budget ~\$35–45 USD / ~\$48–62 CAD for two
- **Dinner:** Option A: Portillo's (~\$48 CAD) or Gibsons Steakhouse (~\$124 CAD) | Option B/C: ~\$76 CAD

Daily Cost Breakdown (Option A — Architecture Day)

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$200
Meals	\$110
Architecture River Cruise (2 pp)	\$143
Willis Tower Skydeck (2 pp)	\$88
CTA day pass (2 pp)	\$14
Daily Total	\$555
Daily Total — Option B (Museums)	~\$591
Daily Total — Option C (Neighbourhoods)	~\$390

Day 15: Saturday, July 18, 2026 — Chicago → Hamilton 🏠

Route: Chicago, IL → Hamilton, ON

Distance: ~750 km | **Driving Time:** ~7 hours (including border)

Final day — a solid but very doable drive home. Leave Chicago by 8:30 AM, cross into Canada at either the Ambassador Bridge (Windsor/Detroit) or Blue Water Bridge (Port Huron/Sarnia), and you're home in Hamilton by mid-to-late afternoon. The drive across southern Michigan is easy highway miles — a pleasant last chapter to the trip.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Final hotel breakfast in Chicago; check out by 8:30 AM
- Depart Chicago 8:30 AM on I-90 East / I-94 East
- **Tip:** Avoid Chicago inner loop traffic — use I-90 East directly from downtown (not I-55 or I-290)
- Drive through Indiana — highway miles, easy driving
- **Indiana Dunes National Park** (optional quick stop, ~45 min detour off I-94 at Chesterton, IN)
 - Drive to **West Beach or Kemil Beach** for a final Lake Michigan view
 - Walking: ~150 m from Kemil Beach lot to water's edge (flat sand)
 - Entry covered by America the Beautiful Pass

Midday:

- Cross into Michigan; lunch stop in **Kalamazoo or Battle Creek, MI** (~\$30 CAD)

- Continue on I-94 East toward Detroit

Early Afternoon:

- Reach border crossing: **Ambassador Bridge (Windsor) or Blue Water Bridge (Port Huron/Sarnia)**
 - Check wait times at cbsa-asfc.gc.ca before choosing crossing
 - Blue Water Bridge (Port Huron/Sarnia) typically has shorter waits on summer Saturdays
 - Have duty-free declarations ready; declare all purchases
 - NEXUS lane if you have cards

Afternoon:

- Cross into Ontario; drive east on Hwy 402 → 401 or Hwy 40 toward Hamilton
- **Arrive Hamilton: ~3:30–4:30 PM ET** 🎉

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at Chicago hotel
- **Lunch:** Kalamazoo or Battle Creek, MI (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** HOME — your own kitchen or a local Hamilton favourite to celebrate! (~\$0 or local budget)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Meals	\$30
Gas (~68L @ \$1.60/L)	\$109
Border crossing / duty	\$5
Optional Indiana Dunes stop	\$0 (pass covers entry)
Daily Total	\$144

Complete Cost Breakdown Summary

Accommodation (14 nights)

Location	Nights	Total CAD	Notes
Mackinaw City, MI	1	\$131	Day 1
Wisconsin Dells, WI	1	\$121	Day 2 (outbound)
Rapid City, SD	2	\$290	Days 3–4
Cody, WY	1	\$159	Day 5
West Yellowstone, MT	3	\$558	Days 6–8 (Day 8 no holiday premium now)
Jackson, WY	1	\$172	Day 9
Sioux Falls, SD	1	\$150	Day 10 (return) — replaces Custer

Location	Nights	Total CAD	Notes
Wisconsin Dells, WI	2	\$356	Days 11–12 (Chula Vista, 2 nights)
Chicago, IL	2	\$400	Days 13–14 (2 full nights)
Kalamazoo, MI	1	\$131	Eliminated — drive Chicago → Hamilton direct
Custer, SD	1	\$135	Eliminated — redundant after Days 4–5
Des Moines, IA	1	\$145	Eliminated — off-route detour
TOTAL ACCOMMODATION	14	\$2,337	3 hotels removed, Chicago upgraded to 2 nights

Meals (15 days)

Average per day: ~\$102 CAD (slightly higher due to 2 Chicago days and Dells supper club)

TOTAL MEALS: ~\$1,530 CAD

Fuel (~5,600 km total)

Return route is slightly shorter — eliminates Custer/Des Moines detour, saves ~100 km.

Estimated consumption: ~520 litres total

Rate: \$1.60/L CAD average

TOTAL FUEL: ~\$832 CAD

Park Entries & Attractions

Attraction	Cost CAD	Notes
America the Beautiful Annual Pass	\$110	Covers 6 parks/monuments
Custer State Park	\$28	Day 4
Crazy Horse Memorial	\$41	Day 4
Buffalo Bill Center	\$58	Day 6
Wisconsin Dells — Lost Canyon (2 pp)	\$44	Day 12
Wisconsin Dells — Wisconsin Ducks (2 pp)	\$96	Day 12
Wisconsin Dells — Witches Gulch Boat Tour (2 pp)	\$110	Day 12
Chicago parking (SpotHero, 2 nights)	\$60	Days 13–14
Chicago Architecture River Cruise (2 pp)	\$143	Day 14
Willis Tower Skydeck (2 pp)	\$88	Day 14
CTA day passes, Chicago (2 pp × 2 days)	\$28	Days 13–14
Bridge/border tolls	\$20	
TOTAL ENTRIES	\$826	

Attraction	Cost CAD	Notes
Optional: Art Institute Chicago (2 pp)	\$71	Day 13
Optional: Field + Shedd + Adler (2 pp)	\$222	Day 14 Option B
With all optional activities	~\$1,119	

Miscellaneous

- Groceries/snacks: \$55 CAD
- Emergency fund: \$150 CAD
- **TOTAL MISC: \$205 CAD**

GRAND TOTAL COST

Category	Original (CAD)	Updated (CAD)	Change
Accommodation	\$2,183	\$2,337	+\$154 (extra Chicago night, upgraded Dells hotel)
Meals	\$1,470	\$1,530	+\$60 (Dells supper club, Chicago extra day)
Fuel	\$848	\$832	-\$16 (shorter return route)
Attractions/Entries	\$297	\$826	+\$529 (full Dells tours + Chicago attractions)
Miscellaneous	\$205	\$205	—
TOTAL	\$5,003	\$5,730 CAD	+\$727
Per Person	\$2,502	\$2,865 CAD	+\$363/person
Cost per day	~\$334	~\$382 CAD	

The extra \$727 CAD buys you: a complete Wisconsin Dells experience (3 boat/canyon tours), 1.5 full days in Chicago instead of a rushed half-afternoon, the Architecture River Cruise, and Willis Tower Skydeck. Excellent value for what you get.

With all Chicago optional activities (Art Institute + Museums): ~\$6,022 CAD total (~\$3,011/person)

Walking Distance Master Summary

This section provides a at-a-glance reference of walking effort across all key attraction days.

Day	Location	Min. Walking (m)	Notes
Day 4	Mount Rushmore, Custer SP, Crazy Horse	~700 m	All flat/paved if avoiding Presidential Trail

Day	Location	Min. Walking (m)	Notes
Day 5	Badlands + Devils Tower	~400–900 m	Drive-up overlooks dominate; one optional boardwalk
Day 6	Cody → Lamar Valley → Yellowstone Lake → West Yellowstone	~280 m	Lamar Valley 100% from car; Fishing Bridge + Lake Butte are drive-ups
Day 7	Yellowstone Lower Loop	~3,500 m	All flat boardwalks; spread across full day
Day 8	Yellowstone Upper Loop	~1,800 m	Porcelain Basin + Mammoth Lower Terraces + Artist Point
Day 9	Grand Teton — Full Day	~1,010 m	8 iconic viewpoints north → south; longest single walk is 200 m
Day 10	Sioux Falls — Falls Park	~200–400 m	Upper platform is all you need; late afternoon golden light
Day 11	La Crosse Grandad Bluff + Dells arrival	~200–600 m	Drive to Grandad Bluff summit; Riverwalk stroll in evening
Day 12	Wisconsin Dells — Full Tour Day	~550–800 m	Witches Gulch boardwalk (500 m) is the only real walk; all tours seated
Day 13	Chicago — Arrival Afternoon	~1,500 m	Bean + Riverwalk + Navy Pier; entirely flat
Day 14	Chicago — Full Day (Option A)	~3,000–4,000 m	Architecture cruise + Magnificent Mile + Skydeck; full day at easy pace

Total walking across all major sightseeing days: ~13–14 km spread across 11 days — just over 1 km per day on average, all on flat urban or boardwalk surfaces.

Important Notes & Tips

National Parks Pass

- **America the Beautiful Annual Pass:** \$80 USD (~\$110 CAD)
- Covers 1 vehicle and all passengers — perfect for couples!
- Valid at: Yellowstone, Grand Teton, Badlands, Wind Cave, Devils Tower, Mount Rushmore, Indiana Dunes
- Purchase at first park (Badlands on Day 5) or buy online beforehand at store.usgs.gov/recreationpass
- Physical pass ships within 3 weeks — allow time or buy at park
- Keep pass in glove box for easy access at park entrances

EV Charging Strategy for Mitsubishi Outlander PHEV

- PHEV charging planned at: Mackinaw City, Rapid City, Cody, West Yellowstone (3 nights), Jackson, Sioux Falls, Wisconsin Dells/Chula Vista (2 nights), Chicago (2 nights)
- **Note:** Kalamazoo and Des Moines overnight stops have been eliminated from the revised return route

- All Level 2 overnight charging at hotels (220V, 3–5 hour full charge)
- Cost: Most hotel chargers are complimentary or \$5–10 per session
- Can run hybrid mode continuously if needed — don't worry about charging gaps
- ChargePoint and PlugShare apps — find public charging stations en route
- Electric range: ~35–40 km per charge; use for city driving to save gas
- **Tip:** Request room near charging station when checking in

Peak Summer Crowds (July)

- July is **peak tourist season** across all parks — expect crowds every day, not just holidays
- Yellowstone: Arrive at each site before 8:00 AM to beat parking congestion
- Grand Teton: Snake River Overlook, Jenny Lake, and Mormon Row are extremely popular — go early or late afternoon
- Badlands: Much lighter crowds than Yellowstone; mornings are still best
- **Start early every day** — the difference between a stress-free visit and a chaotic one is arriving before 9 AM

Money-Saving Tips

1. **Hotel breakfasts:** All hotels include free breakfast — saves \$20–30/day CAD
2. **Pack lunches:** Buy groceries for in-park days (bread, deli meat, cheese, fruit, snacks)
3. **Gas apps:** Use GasBuddy or Waze for cheapest gas stations (can save \$10–20/tank)
4. **Annual Pass:** Saves \$70+ USD vs buying individual park entries
5. **Off-peak dining:** Eat lunch as main meal (dinner prices are 20–30% higher)
6. **Free water:** Refill bottles at park visitor centres instead of buying
7. **Group discounts:** Ask about CAA/AAA discounts at hotels and attractions
8. **Credit card rewards:** Use travel rewards card for USD purchases (check foreign transaction fees)

Border Crossing Tips

Entering USA (Day 1):

- Bring passports (REQUIRED — no exceptions)
- NEXUS cards if you have them (use NEXUS lanes for faster processing)
- Border wait times: Check cbp.gov/bwt before crossing
- Best crossing points: Ambassador Bridge (Detroit/Windsor) or Blue Water Bridge (Port Huron/Sarnia)
- Peak wait times: Weekdays 7–9 AM, 4–6 PM; Weekends 10 AM–4 PM
- Have hotel address ready for first night
- Declare all food items (no fresh fruits/vegetables allowed into USA)
- **July 4 tip:** Cross early (before 8 AM) — Independence Day brings heavier border traffic

Returning to Canada (Day 15):

- Duty-free exemption after 48+ hours: \$800 CAD per person
- Declare ALL purchases (receipts ready)
- Alcohol limit: 1.5L wine OR 1.14L spirits OR 8.5L beer per person
- ArriveCAN — check current requirements before trip at cbsa-asfc.gc.ca

Weather Considerations (Early–Mid July)

- **Yellowstone elevations:** 2,000–3,000m (6,500–9,800 ft)
- Temperature ranges:
 - Yellowstone: 5–25°C days, -2 to 5°C nights
 - South Dakota: 20–30°C days, 10–15°C nights
 - Chicago: 22–28°C, humid
- Afternoon thunderstorms common in mountains (2–4 PM) — plan to be back at car by 2 PM
- Snow possible at high elevations even in July
- Layering is key: Start day with jacket, strip to t-shirt by noon
- UV intensity is significantly stronger at high elevation (SPF 50+ essential)
- Wildfire season: Check air quality forecasts at AirNow.gov

Vehicle Preparation & Road Trip Essentials

Pre-departure vehicle inspection:

- Oil change if due within trip dates
- Check tire pressure and tread depth (including spare)
- Top off all fluids (coolant, brake fluid, windshield washer)
- Test lights, wipers, horn; check battery health
- Verify PHEV charging cable is in vehicle

Emergency car kit:

- Jumper cables, tire inflator/sealant, flashlight with extra batteries
- Basic tool kit, duct tape, ice scraper (even in summer — high elevations!)
- Tow rope
- CAA/AAA membership: Verify coverage extends to USA

Cell Phone Coverage — Know the Dead Zones

Good coverage: All major cities and highways, I-90 corridor in South Dakota, Chicago area, Michigan

Spotty/No coverage: Yellowstone (60% of park has no service — Verizon best), Grand Teton (limited to main roads), rural Wyoming (large gaps between towns), Badlands (visitor centres only)

Solutions:

- Download offline maps for entire route
- Screenshot hotel addresses/phone numbers
- Print physical itinerary
- Let family know you may be unreachable for days at a time

Food Storage & Wildlife Safety — CRITICAL

Wildlife Distance Rules:

- 25 metres (75 feet): Bison, elk, deer, moose, bighorn sheep
- 100 metres (300 feet): Bears, wolves, coyotes
- Use zoom lens for photos — NOT zoom feet!

Food Storage in Parks:

- Never leave food in open vehicle
- Store in hard-sided containers or trunk
- Use bear-proof trash cans
- Don't eat in car then leave windows down

If Wildlife Approaches:

- Stay calm, don't run; back away slowly
- Get in vehicle if available
- Bear spray only as last resort (within 7–10m)

Driving Safety — Mountain & Rural Roads

- Speed limits: Strictly enforced in national parks (45 mph / 70 km/h max)
- Many mountain roads have sharp hairpin turns (10–20 mph / 15–30 km/h)
- Use low gear on descents to avoid brake fade
- Wildlife crossings: Dawn/dusk most dangerous — scan roadsides constantly
- In Wyoming, gas stations can be 100+ km apart — fill at half tank

Health & Safety

Altitude Sickness:

- Yellowstone is 2,300m (7,500 ft)
- Symptoms: Headache, nausea, fatigue, dizziness
- Prevention: Hydrate (3–4L water/day), avoid alcohol first 24h, rest frequently

Medical Facilities in Yellowstone:

- Clinics at Mammoth, Old Faithful, Lake (May–Sept only)
- Emergency: Dial 911 from any park phone
- Nearest hospitals: Jackson (WY), Cody (WY), Bozeman (MT)

Top 15 Must-See Sites — No Hiking Required

All accessible via car, short walks, or wheelchair-accessible boardwalks:

1. **Grand Prismatic Spring, Yellowstone** — Easy boardwalk loop, most photographed thermal feature
2. **Old Faithful Geyser, Yellowstone** — View from benches, erupts every ~90 minutes
3. **Grand Canyon of Yellowstone — Artist Point** — Paved 150 m path to iconic waterfall view
4. **Mount Rushmore** — View from Grand View Terrace, 250 m from parking
5. **Badlands Overlooks** — 13 scenic pullouts along Loop Road, all roadside
6. **Mammoth Hot Springs Terraces** — Easy boardwalk loops + drive-through upper terraces
7. **Devils Tower** — View from 200 m paved path from parking area
8. **Mormon Row Barns, Grand Teton** — Drive-up photo ops with mountain backdrop
9. **Cloud Gate ("The Bean"), Chicago** — Walk around mirrored sculpture in Millennium Park
10. **Crazy Horse Memorial** — View from visitor centre terrace, 100 m from parking
11. **Wildlife Loop Road, Custer State Park** — 18-mile scenic drive to see bison herds
12. **Hayden Valley, Yellowstone** — Wildlife viewing from pullouts (bison, elk, bears)

13. **Needles Highway, South Dakota** — Scenic drive through granite spires with tunnels
 14. **West Thumb Geyser Basin** — Lakeside boardwalk with colourful hot springs, 0.9 km flat loop
 15. **Snake River Overlook, Grand Teton** — Famous Ansel Adams viewpoint, roadside pullout
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Pre-Trip Checklist

3 Months Before (By April 4, 2026)

- ☐ Book all 14 hotel accommodations (especially West Yellowstone for peak July)
- ☐ Purchase America the Beautiful Annual Pass online (optional — can buy at first park)
- ☐ Research and book travel insurance
- ☐ Check passport expiry dates (must be valid through January 2027)
- ☐ Apply for NEXUS cards if interested
- ☐ Book any special dining reservations (Chicago deep dish restaurants)

1 Month Before (By June 4, 2026)

- ☐ Confirm all hotel reservations via email/phone
- ☐ Schedule Outlander PHEV service (oil change, tire rotation, multi-point inspection)
- ☐ Check vehicle insurance covers USA travel; verify CAA membership covers USA
- ☐ Download: Yellowstone NPS app, GasBuddy, PlugShare, SpotHero
- ☐ Order physical road atlas as backup
- ☐ Check for road closures (WYDOT, SDDOT) and park alerts (nps.gov/yell)
- ☐ Set credit card travel notifications (July 4 – July 18, USA)

2 Weeks Before (By June 20, 2026)

- ☐ Complete vehicle service/maintenance
- ☐ Download offline maps: Michigan, Wisconsin, South Dakota, Wyoming, Montana, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana, Grand Teton, Yellowstone NPS
- ☐ Purchase road trip snacks (non-perishable)
- ☐ Start breaking in walking shoes if new

1 Week Before (By June 27, 2026)

- ☐ Final hotel confirmation calls (especially West Yellowstone)
- ☐ Print entire itinerary as backup; print hotel addresses and phone numbers
- ☐ Pack bags; test all electronics; charge all devices fully
- ☐ Wash car and clean interior; check tire pressure (including spare)
- ☐ Prepare "car kit" (first aid, flashlight, emergency supplies)
- ☐ Buy cooler; purchase reusable water bottles; stock car snacks
- ☐ Notify neighbours/family of travel dates; arrange mail/newspaper hold
- ☐ Withdraw USD cash (\$200–300)

Day Before Departure (Friday, July 3, 2026)

- ☐ Full tank of gas; fully charge PHEV battery
- ☐ Check all tire pressures (including spare); test all lights; clean windshield

- ☐ Load luggage into vehicle (leave room for souvenirs!)
- ☐ Set up phone mounts/chargers in car; pack cooler with drinks and snacks
- ☐ Double-check passports are packed
- ☐ Final home check: lights off, thermostat adjusted, stove off, windows/doors locked, garage closed
- ☐ Set alarms for 7:00 AM (depart by 9:00 AM)
- ☐ Get good night's sleep!

Departure Morning (Saturday, July 4, 2026)

- ☐ Quick breakfast at home; fill coffee thermoses
- ☐ Final house walkthrough; set home security
- ☐ Take photo of odometer (track mileage)
- ☐ Plug in phone navigation; review Day 1 route
- **Departure time: 9:00 AM ET — Let's go!**

During Trip — Daily Checklist

- ☐ Check weather for next day each evening
- ☐ Charge all electronics overnight
- ☐ Charge PHEV at hotel (if available)
- ☐ Review next day's route before bed
- ☐ Keep receipts organised
- ☐ Refill water bottles; restock car snacks
- ☐ Stretch legs every 2 hours of driving
- ☐ Stay hydrated (especially at altitude)

Return Home (Saturday, July 18) — Post-Trip

- ☐ Unload vehicle; unpack; do laundry
- ☐ Download photos from camera and back up to cloud
- ☐ Calculate actual trip costs vs budget
- ☐ Share photos with family/friends!
- ☐ Schedule post-trip vehicle inspection if needed

Emergency Contacts

Contact	Number
USA Emergency	911
Yellowstone Dispatch	307-344-7381
CAA Roadside Assistance	1-800-222-4357
Poison Control (USA)	1-800-222-1222
Canadian Consulate Chicago	312-616-1860

Alternative Options to Consider

If You Want to Cut 1 Day: Skip Des Moines stop (Day 12) — go directly Chicago from Sioux Falls (~650 km). Saves 1 accommodation night (~\$145 CAD). Total trip: 14 days instead of 15.

If You Want MORE Chicago Time: Add extra night in Chicago (2 nights total). Visit: Art Institute, Field Museum, Shedd Aquarium, Navy Pier, Architecture tour. Cost: +\$200 accommodation, +\$100 meals = +\$300 CAD total.

If Budget is Tight: Skip optional activities (Wisconsin Dells tour, Chicago observation deck) — saves \$137 CAD. Pack more meals — saves \$200–300 CAD. Could reduce total to ~\$4,200–4,400 CAD.

If You Want More Nature, Less Cities: Skip Chicago overnight (save \$200). Add second night in Jackson, WY for extra Grand Teton time.

Trip Statistics

Stat	Detail
Total Distance	5,700 km
Days	15 (14 nights)
States Visited	9 (Michigan, Wisconsin, Minnesota, South Dakota, Wyoming, Montana, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana)
National Parks	Badlands, Wind Cave, Devils Tower, Grand Teton, Yellowstone, Indiana Dunes
Average Daily Cost	~\$334 CAD
Total Estimated Cost	~\$5,003 CAD (\$2,502/person)

All prices are estimates based on 2026 projections. Actual costs may vary. Gas prices fluctuate — budget accordingly. Book accommodations early for July peak season.

Updated: June 2026 — Trip dates revised to July 4–18, 2026. Walking distances and optimization tips added throughout.

Have an amazing trip! Safe travels! 🚗 ✨ 🏡